

Veni, vidi, vici

Veni, vidi, vici (Classical Latin: [ˈweːniː ˈwiːdiː ˈwiːkiː], Ecclesiastical Latin: [ˈveːni ˈviːdi ˈviːtʃi]; "I came; I saw; I conquered") is a Latin phrase used to refer to a swift, conclusive victory. The phrase is popularly attributed to [Julius Caesar](#) who, according to [Appian](#),^[1] used the phrase in a letter to the [Roman Senate](#) around 47 BC after he had achieved a quick victory in his short war against [Pharnaces II of Pontus](#) at the [Battle of Zela](#) (modern-day [Zile, Turkey](#)).^[2]



A view from the 2000-year-old historical castle [column](#) piece in [Zile, Turkey](#) where [Julius Caesar](#) said "Veni, vidi, vici".

The phrase is attributed in [Plutarch's](#) *Life of Caesar* and [Suetonius's](#) *Lives of the Twelve Caesars: Julius*. Plutarch writes that Caesar used it in a report to Amantius, a friend of his in Rome.^[3] Suetonius states that Caesar displayed the three words as an inscription during his Pontic triumph.^[4]

Allusions and references

Variations of the sentence *Veni, vidi, vici* are often quoted, and also used in music, art, literature, and entertainment.

[Veni, Vidi, Vici \(1896\)](#)



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[Robert Browne Hall's](#) 1896 march, *Veni, Vidi, Vici*, performed by the [United States Air Force Band](#).

Since the time of Caesar, the phrase has been used in military contexts. [King Jan III of Poland](#) alluded to

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it after the 17th-century [Battle of Vienna](#), saying *Venimus, Vidimus, Deus vicit* ("We came, we saw, God conquered").^[5] In 2011, then [US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton](#) referred to the death of [Muammar Gaddafi](#) with a similar phrase, saying "We came, we saw, he died".^{[6][7]}

The sentence has also been used in music, including several well-known works over the years. The opening of [Handel's](#) 1724 opera *Giulio Cesare* contains the line: *Curio, Cesare venne, e vide e vinse* ("Curio, Caesar came, saw and conquered"). In popular music, it is expected that the audience will know the original quotation, so modified versions are frequently used. This can range from slight changes in perspective, as in the title song in the musical *Mame* (*You came, you saw, you conquered*) or the 1936 song *These Foolish Things (Remind Me of You)* (*You came, you saw, you conquered me*) to wordplay, such as in the album title *Veni Vidi Vicious* by Swedish band [The Hives](#) or [Pitbull's](#) song "Fireball" (*I saw, I came, I conquered Or should I say, I saw I conquered, I came*) or [Ja Rule's](#) debut album *Venni Vetti Vecci*. [ASAP Rocky](#) and [Skepta](#) use a variation in their song *Praise the Lord (Da Shine)* with "I came, I saw, I praise the Lord, then break the law"



The phrase appears in a variety of cultural contexts, such as this [Philip Morris](#) logo, from a pack of [Marlboro](#) cigarettes.

The phrase has also been heavily referenced in literature and film. The title of French poet [Victor Hugo's](#) *Veni, vidi, vixi* ("I came, I saw, I lived"), written after the death of his daughter Leopoldine at age 19 in 1843, uses the allusion with its first verse: *J'ai bien assez vécu...* ("I have lived quite long enough..."). [Peter Venkman](#), one of the protagonists in the 1984 film *Ghostbusters*, delivers a humorous variation: "We came. We saw. We kicked its ass!" This line was among the 400 nominees for the [AFI's 100 Years...100 Movie Quotes](#).^[8]

Grammar

Latin

Veni, vidi, and vici are [first person](#) singular [perfect indicative active](#) forms of the Latin verbs *venire*, *videre*, and *vincere*, which mean "to come", "to see", and "to conquer", respectively. The sentence's form is classed as a [tricolon](#) and a [hendiatris](#).

English

The English phrase "I came, I saw, I conquered" employs what is known as a [comma splice](#).

Grammarians generally agree that using a comma to join two independent clauses should be done sparingly.^[9] Sometimes, the comma splice is avoided by using a semicolon instead: "I came; I saw; I conquered".^[10] Alternatively, "I came, I saw, I conquered" can be justified as an example of [asyndeton](#), where the lack of the expected conjunction emphasizes the suddenness and swiftness of Caesar's victories. Similarly, this sentence also serves as a famous example of an [alliteration](#) due to the repeated use of its first consonant.

See also

- [Isocolon](#)
- [List of Latin phrases](#)
- [Ut est rerum omnium magister usus](#)

Notes

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- Suetonius, *Lives of the Twelve Caesars: Julius* (https://penelope.uchicago.edu/Thayer/E/Roman/Texts/Suetonius/12Caesars/Julius*.html#37) from penelope.uchicago.edu

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6. Daly, Corbett (20 October 2011). "Clinton on Qaddafi: "We came, we saw, he died" " (<https://www.cbsnews.com/news/clinton-on-qaddafi-we-came-we-saw-he-died/>) . CBSNEWS. CBS Interactive Inc. Retrieved 7 November 2014.
7. Shaw, Lucas (2011-10-21). "Hillary Clinton on Gaddafi: "We Came, We Saw, He Died" (Video)" (<https://www.thewrap.com/hillary-clinton-gaddafi-we-came-we-saw-he-died-video-32058/>) . *TheWrap*. Retrieved 2024-11-14. "In the second of two videos showing her reaction to different stages of reports, in this case the confirmation of Gaddafi's death, Clinton proclaims "We came, we saw, he died." For those who have not recently brushed up on their Roman history, that is a reference to Julius Caesar's famous line "veni, vidi, vici," which means "I came, I saw, I conquered." "
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10. Smith, Christopher. *Barron's GED Canada: High School Equivalency Exam* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=-VSh9d3egYQC&pg=PA170>) , p. 170 (Barron's Educational Series, 2008).